Merve Demirel

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Institute for International Economic Studies
Stockholm University
SE-106 91 Stockholm, Sweden

Email: merve.demirel@iies.su.se
Website: demirelmerve.com
Phone: +46 76 053 24 79
Citizenship: Turkey
Residence: Sweden (permanent)

Education

2020–2027 **Stockholm University (IIES)**, PhD in Economics (expected June 2027)
2024–2025 **Columbia University**, Visiting Scholar, hosted by Laura Boudreau
2017–2019 **Stockholm School of Economics**, MSc in Economics
Exchange semester: University of Tokyo
2012–2017 **Koç University**, BA in Economics, BA in Business
Exchange semesters: National University of Singapore, HEC Paris

References

Johannes Haushofer
Cornell University
haushofer@cornell.edu

Anna Tompsett
Stockholm University
anna.tompsett@iies.su.se

Tessa Bold
Stockholm University
tessa.bold@iies.su.se

Laia Navarro-Sola
Stockholm University
laia.navarrosola@iies.su.se

Research Fields

Development Economics, Labor Economics, Gender

Job Market Paper

Migration Costs and Higher Education: Experimental Evidence from India

Large gaps in economic opportunity across places in developing countries persist alongside low rates of migration, which a large literature attributes to the non-pecuniary costs of leaving home. This paper asks whether these costs hold prospective college students back from migrating for college, and whether access to a migrant peer can reduce perceived costs and facilitate migration. I follow 1,682 final-year secondary students across 52 schools in Maharashtra, India, over a full year as they make one of the most consequential decisions of their lives, whether and where to continue their education. I measure their perceived migration costs, and run a randomized controlled trial offering half of them a phone-based mentorship program that pairs each student with a university student who migrated for college. At baseline, the average student would forgo a 129% increase in expected post-graduation earnings rather than study away from home, an amount that rises steeply with distance. Beliefs about the difficulty of moving, safety, parental approval, and happiness away from home account for much of it. Mentorship shapes choices, but only on the margin: a pre-specified educational migration index rises by 0.16 standard deviations, driven by applications and moves to closer destinations, rather than more distant major cities, and driven almost exclusively by male students. Non-pecuniary beliefs about the distant cities do not improve, suggesting that high migration costs are unlikely to be driven by misperceptions.

Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0016735.

Working Papers

Distance, Gender, and Access to Elite Higher Education: Evidence from India's Centralized Engineering Admissions (with Xuanzhe Hou and Yash Kanoria)
Earlier version circulated as "How Far Would You Go? Higher Education and Migration Decisions in India."

Identity and Human Capital Investment: Evidence from the Veiling Ban Removal in Turkey (with Avenia Ghazarian)
HoSS Working Paper 2026-1, Stockholm School of Economics.

Moving to Opportunity Abroad: The Effects of International Educational Migration (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Pérez Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
World Bank Social Policy and Labor Discussion Paper No. 2702. Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0012924.

Educational Migration Prospects and Human Capital Investments: Evidence from a Uganda-Germany College Access Program (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Pérez Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
World Bank Social Policy and Labor Discussion Paper No. 2702. Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0009992.

Work in Progress

International Migration and Identity Formation: The Perception of the Self and Others (with Toman Barsbai, Philipp Moskopp, Marcello Pérez Alvarez and Matthias Sutter)
Pre-registered: AEARCTR-0016846.

Harassment in Colleges: A Bottom-Up Approach (with Eugenia Frezza, Emmanuel Keith Kisaame and Arne Nasgowitz)
Pilot stage. Funded by J-PAL Crime and Violence Initiative and Leading House Africa.

Research Grants

2026	**J-PAL**, Displaced Livelihoods Initiative (USD 200,000); **Max Planck Society** (USD 171,300); **ECONtribute** (USD 23,100); **Leading House Africa**, Swiss Tropical and Public Health Institute (USD 17,100)
2025	**J-PAL**, Jobs and Opportunity Initiative / Social Protection Initiative (USD 250,000); **ECONtribute** (USD 67,800); **J-PAL**, Crime and Violence Initiative, Exploratory Research and Travel Grant (USD 9,995)
2024	**Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences** (USD 28,200); **The Weiss Fund**, Travel and Piloting Grant (USD 14,938); **Mannerfelt Foundation** (USD 3,700); **Stockholm Center for Global Asia** (USD 1,400); **SurveyCTO**, Primary Data Collection Research Grant
2023	**World Bank**, Innovation Challenge on Jobs and Migration (USD 279,900); **ECONtribute** (USD 54,100); **PEDL**, Exploratory Research Grant (USD 6,200); **Mannerfelt Foundation** (USD 2,800); **IIES** (USD 1,900)
2022	**ECONtribute** (USD 105,000)

Fellowships and Honors

2021 **Jan Wallander and Tom Hedelius Foundation** (USD 58,300)
2018 **Stockholms Grosshandlarsocietetet**, Scholarship for Studies Abroad (USD 1,700)
2017 **Af Jochnik Foundation**, MSc Scholarship (USD 35,100)
2016 **European Bank for Reconstruction and Development**, Starting Grant
2012 **Koç University**, Full Merit Scholarship

Teaching Experience

2021 **Stockholm University**, Intermediate Microeconomics, TA to Lars Vahtrik
2019 **Stockholm School of Economics**, Introductory Microeconomics, TA to Richard Friberg
2018 **Stockholm School of Economics**, International Economics, TA to Paul Segerström

Research Experience

2018–2020 **Stockholm School of Economics**, Research Assistant for Martina Björkman-Nyqvist, Abhijeet Singh and Pamela Campa
2018 **Stockholm University**, Research Assistant for Anna Tompsett

Talks and Conferences ([†]scheduled)

2026 Oxford Development Economics Workshop; RFBerlin Migration Forum; Women in Economics Network Conference; Talent Economics Conference; ASWEDE Conference[†]; The Economics of Migration Junior Webinar[†]
2025 Tilburg University; University of Groningen; Development Colloquium, Columbia University; Interdisciplinary PhD Workshop in Sustainable Development, Columbia University; SEEDEC, Max Planck Institute Bonn
2024 ASWEDE Conference
2023 European Network Development Conference; ASWEDE Conference
2022 ASWEDE Conference

Refereeing

Journals: *Science*, *Journal of Population Economics*

Service

2020–2023 **Women in Economics Initiative**, Board Member

Other Experience

2016–2017 **Jana Impact**, Co-founder of a social enterprise for refugee employment
2016–2017 **Carma Consultancy**, Business Development Intern

Languages

Turkish (native), English (fluent), Swedish (intermediate), French (beginner)